



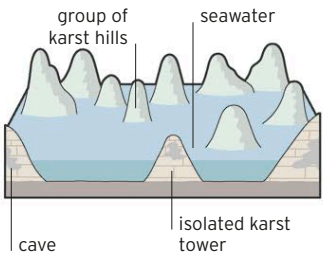
The Krabi Coastline

An area of southern Thailand notable for its fantastic karst formations

The limestone rock of the Krabi coastline originally formed about 260 million years ago. At that time, a shallow sea covered what is now south Asia and slowly built up deposits of shells and coral fragments. These eventually formed layers of limestone, which were later pushed upward and tipped over when India began to collide with Eurasia some 50 million years ago. Around Krabi and Phang Nga Bay to its north, chemical erosion of these limestone layers by rainwater (which combines with dissolved carbon dioxide to form carbonic acid), followed by a rising sea level, created a landscape of thousands of craggy karst islands and hills. These include a number of isolated towers that rise to heights of up to 690 ft (210 m).

HOW THE COASTLINE FORMED

The Krabi coastline is a drowned karst landscape—one in which an existing landscape of limestone hills and towers became inundated by the sea (see panel, p.248).



△ **HIDDEN PARADISE**
At the island of Phi Phi Le, the drowning of the coastline has created a hidden lagoon and secret beach.

▷ **HANGING ROCK**
Near the entrance to a small cave, stalactites covered in tropical vegetation hang from an eroded mass of limestone.

